

Long Drive with Obama

President Barack Obama took test drive on, Chevrolet Volt, an electric car, during a visit to the Compact Power battery plant in Holland

Charging station

First public electric charging station in New York was installed recently by Coulomb Technologies

India, the nation choked by e-waste



Photographs: Tushar Goyal

The dark reality of e-waste is a gripping one with a thriving industry exploiting cheap labour

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The technological zeitgeist of modern society is part of a package, which includes an unlikely desideratum – e-waste.

Sure, the hip iPad, the immaculate smartphone, the cool air-conditioner, the new digital camera, the hot LCD TV enhance the quality of your life in all sorts of ways, but at some point in the future, these devices, which seem incredibly advanced today, will go obsolete. And once you let go of them, they will have to make their final journey to the myriad graveyards for obsolete devices that are mostly located in the heart of dirt-poor slums of India. Ultimately it befalls on the slum dwellers to perform the dangerous

job of electronic-scavengers; working with most medieval tools – they try to eke out a living, by extracting some valuable material from a plethora of discarded devices.

Rag pickers sifting through filthy garbage dumps in search of plastic or paper are a common sight in India, and so is the visual of young children risking their lives while trying to pick apart old computers, radios and air-conditioners. India's informal e-waste industry is notorious for working on a shoestring budget. As they work without any protection, at times with their bare hands, the labourers, employed by the informal e-waste industry, often end up suffering from skin infections, and from other debilitating diseases of blood systems and kidneys. In case of severe exposure to toxic material, they might also suffer brain swelling,

which might result in paralysis or death.

The Centre for Science and Environment (<http://www.cseindia.org>), in its May 18, 2010 press release, has made the following observation: “India generated 330,000 tonnes of e-waste in 2007 – equal to 110 million laptops. About 10 per cent of the e-waste generated is recycled every year; the remaining is refurbished, and the unorganised sector is right behind almost all of it. Informal dealers refurbish and make money from e-waste.” In India the situation is being compounded by the fact that it is not only the country's burgeoning middle class that is discarding a huge amount of electronic waste, ranging from personal computers, optical disc players, mobile phones and other portable devices, even the rich Western countries have started shipping their e-waste to our ports. Kushal P S Yadav of CSE says, “According to our estimate illegal import of e-waste in the country stands at about 50,000 tonnes annually. Loopholes in laws facilitate this.”

What can be done?

A good way of disposing electronic products, which are in working order, but are no longer required by you, is to donate them. These days we have a number of organisations, which will accept your old computers and send them to schools where children from poorer sections of society come to study. An organisation called Donate Your PC (<http://donateyourpc.in/v2>), lets you log in and register your donation details, and whenever an NGO requires your PC, you will receive intimation.

You can also dispose off your old PC or any other electronic gizmo by selling it off on eBay. After all, eBay is world's largest online store for used electronic items and its time we took advantage of it for extending the working life of old electronic items. Taking cognisance of the mounting e-waste problem around the world, eBay has come up with a unique Rethink Initiative, whose details you can find out by pointing your browser at: (<http://pages.ebay.com/rethink>). Powered by the tech behemoth Intel, the Rethink Initiative seeks to coordinate the recycling programs of many major manufactures of electronic